

Rage Against the Archive

Institutional Critique through New Media Art

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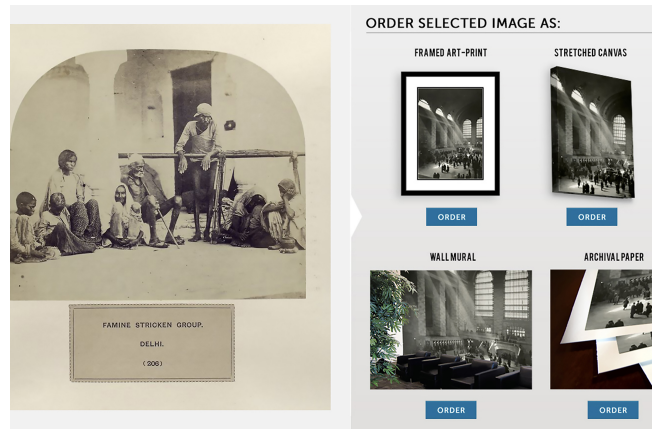
1 DESCRIPTION OF ARTWORK

Rage Against the Archive is an activist project comprising experimental video, performance, and new media art that scrutinizes how the New York Public Library's (NYPL) digital archives catalog and display dehumanizing ethnographic images from colonial India. This work critically probes whether institutional archives inadvertently perpetuate the cycle of colonial exploitation and visual violence. My artistic approach is anchored in a critical paradigm intended to underscore how technology still commodifies the bodies of people of color and how we, as a more conscientious society, should consume certain images online.

The People of India, published between 1868-75, is one of the world's oldest and most comprehensive ethnographic books, commissioned by the British colonial government in India after the 1857 First War of Independence. After experiencing violent uprisings and the first challenge to their colonial rule, the Britishers were keen to understand the native tribes and their cultures to rule them better and prevent future rebellions. The camera, masquerading as an objective device, was employed as an imperial administrative tool to document the natives, "othering" them in this process. Dehumanizing ethnographic portraits were made with an agenda to push forward a pseudo-scientific theory about the racial, economic and cultural inferiority of Indians to justify colonial rule.

How do these problematic historical images exist in our contemporary institutional archives? For this project, I explored NYPL's online archives, which digitized the original book, providing the public free access to these ethnographic images. However, NYPL's website also sells these images of suffering as "Fine Art Prints" in various options. Infusing archival practices with capitalism raises some critical questions.

In my experimental browser-based video, I use Google Chrome's "Inspect Element" feature to modify the underlying HTML code of NYPL's website in an act of Electronic Civil Disobedience, deleting problematic photos and inserting texts on the website that resist the



colonial ideology and the fixity of memory present in the archive. By removing these photos from NYPL's site, I hope to restore some dignity to my ancestors, who have not only been exploited before by colonial photographers, but whose visual representations are also being commodified today. I believe that digital archives, in some cases, instead of being harbingers of free knowledge, are just another way to amplify colonial trauma, and they must be raged against. With my project, I aspire to use web technologies to challenge and disrupt entrenched power structures and propose a decolonized digital archive where technology is harnessed to foster respect and care.

2 PROJECT URL

<https://anshulroy.myportfolio.com/the-people-of-india-project>

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